

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Retail Associate and Cashier English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Retail sales associates, cashiers, fitting-room attendants, and shop-floor customer service staff.

All shops, transactions, stock records, policies, and incidents are fictional English practice. This course covers frontline interactions, not retail strategy, merchandising management, financial advice, or universal consumer-law rules. Follow the employer's actual payment, privacy, safety, and returns procedures; refer exceptions and restricted decisions to the responsible staff.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Finding the item the shopper actually means

Confirm product variation before searching for stock.

02 Comparing fit, materials, and label information

Use label evidence instead of broad claims about quality.

03 Resolving shelf prices and offer conditions

Distinguish an average bundle price from a single-item price.

04 Checking the basket and payment status

Explain the correction and verify the revised quantity and total.

05 Discussing returns and exchanges at the counter

Explain the stated exchange conditions without promising an unavailable replacement.

06 Explaining local stock and collection status

Separate order acknowledgment from pickup readiness.

07 Managing queues and offering practical assistance

Offer a concrete access option without making assumptions about the shopper.

08 Handing over a till and an unfinished query

Give amounts, open checks, and a named next owner.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Finding the item the shopper actually means

Confirm product variation before searching for stock.

CASE

A shopper asks for the blue shirt in an advertisement. The ad shows two blue shirts: linen L214 and cotton C218. The shopper wants a medium cotton shirt; local availability has not been checked. Confirm item and size before discussing stock.

Teach this move

Color alone may describe several items. Use material, code, and size to distinguish them without claiming availability prematurely.

Vocabulary to check: stock-keeping unit, barcode, size range, fitting room.

Model response

The advertisement shows two blue shirts, so let me check which one you mean. Is it the cotton shirt, code C218, in medium? Once we've confirmed that variation, I can check this store's stock. The picture alone doesn't tell us whether your size is available here today.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The question identifies the ambiguity instead of giving uncertain directions.

Second-round challenge

The shopper points at the wrong picture while repeating the cotton code. Clarify before searching.

Language-check answers

1. A - C218 Correct. C218 is the cotton item specified in the case.
2. D - stock-keeping unit Correct. The stock-keeping unit identifies the particular variation.

05 • Conversations

1. Two blue shirts in one advertisement - An associate clarifies a shopper's request on the sales floor.
2. The code is clearer than the display location - A shopper brings a loose item from a mixed display.

3. A gift request without a guessed size - An associate helps a shopper buying a gift.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A barcode belongs to the packaging, not the loose item

A shopper presents a mug inside a box marked for a larger model. The mug base shows M12; the box shows M18. No sale has been entered.

Role A: Associate: compare the two identifiers and find the matching label.

Role B: Shopper: want the smaller M12 mug and its correct price.

Possible opening: Can you scan the box? I put the mug in it myself.

Success checks

- Identify the mug actually selected.
- Keep the mismatched box separate.
- Confirm the exact item before quoting a price.

Add a complication: The shopper assumes the larger model's displayed price applies.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Comparing fit, materials, and label information

Use label evidence instead of broad claims about quality.

CASE

A shopper needs a machine-washable jacket. Jacket A is unlined and its label permits machine washing; B is lined and its label states dry-clean only. Both cost \$60. Compare the stated care requirements without inventing comfort or durability claims.

Teach this move

Price, lining, fit, and care are different features. Identify the deciding requirement and avoid extending the label's meaning beyond what it states.

Vocabulary to check: care label, lining, seam, fit.

Model response

Both jackets are sixty dollars, but their care labels differ. Jacket A is unlined and labelled for machine washing; jacket B is lined and labelled dry-clean only. Since machine washing is your priority, A matches that stated requirement. You can still compare the fit before deciding.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The comparison uses the shopper's criterion rather than an undefined quality claim.

Second-round challenge

The shopper assumes identical prices mean identical care requirements. Return to the two labels.

Language-check answers

1. D - Jacket A Correct. Jacket A's label permits machine washing.
2. C - lining Correct. A lining is the inner fabric layer.

05 • Conversations

1. The care requirement decides the first comparison - An associate compares two jackets with a shopper.

2. Sleeve length and body fit are different - An associate checks a shopper's concern outside the fitting room.
3. Reading a label without inventing a guarantee - A shopper asks about an unfamiliar fabric-care symbol.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | One bag has pockets, the other has lining

Two bags cost \$24. A has a lining but no internal pocket; B has one internal pocket but no lining. The shopper needs a pocket for keys.

Role A: Associate: compare the stated features without equating lining with storage.

Role B: Shopper: prioritize an internal key pocket over lining.

Possible opening: Does lined mean it has a pocket inside?

Success checks

- Explain lining versus pocket.
- Identify B as matching the stated pocket need.
- Avoid unsupported durability claims.

Add a complication: The shopper assumes the more structured appearance proves stronger construction.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Resolving shelf prices and offer conditions

Distinguish an average bundle price from a single-item price.

CASE

A shopper has one juice bottle priced at \$3. The shelf offer says two qualifying bottles for \$5; single bottles remain \$3. The shopper expects one bottle for \$2.50. Explain the quantity condition without treating half the bundle price as the single-item offer.

Teach this move

Use the offer's quantity condition and the same price basis. Don't infer a universal pricing rule from this fictional promotion.

Vocabulary to check: shelf-edge label, unit price, multibuy offer, price check.

Model response

The five-dollar offer applies when you buy two qualifying bottles. One bottle is still three dollars under these displayed terms. Two would average two dollars fifty each, but that average isn't the single-bottle price. Would you like one at three, or two qualifying bottles for five?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The quantity condition stays attached to the discounted price.

Second-round challenge

The second bottle is a nonqualifying flavor. Explain that quantity and qualifying item both matter.

Language-check answers

1. C - three dollars Correct. The single-bottle price remains three dollars.
2. B - unit prices Correct. Unit prices use a common standard quantity.

05 • Conversations

1. One bottle is not half the bundle offer - A cashier explains the fictional juice promotion.
2. The label belongs to the smaller pack - An associate checks a price complaint at a shelf.

3. A larger pack is not automatically the cheaper choice - A shopper compares two fictional quantities of detergent.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | An offer starts tomorrow

The shelf sign states a \$12 promotion beginning Saturday. It is Friday and today's confirmed price is \$15. The shopper misread the starting date.

Role A: Associate: explain the date condition and offer a price check if needed.

Role B: Shopper: willing to return Saturday but want to know whether stock is guaranteed.

Possible opening: I thought the twelve-dollar offer was active today.

Success checks

- State today's and the advertised start date accurately.
- Distinguish price terms from stock availability.
- Avoid promising an unverified reservation.

Add a complication: The shopper assumes returning tomorrow guarantees stock at that price.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Checking the basket and payment status

Explain the correction and verify the revised quantity and total.

CASE

Two \$8 mugs were scanned, but the shopper has only one. There are no additional charges in this exercise. Payment has not begun. Acknowledge the duplicate, correct the recorded quantity through the store's checkout process, and confirm \$8 before payment.

Teach this move

Name the exact duplicate instead of saying the register is wrong generally. Keep a basket correction separate from a refund after payment.

Vocabulary to check: point-of-sale system, subtotal, tender, receipt.

Model response

You're right: the basket shows two mugs, but you have one. I'm sorry about the duplicate scan. I'll correct the quantity before you pay. Your total is now eight dollars, with no additional charges. Please check that the screen shows one mug before we continue.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. A refund would imply money had already been paid.

Second-round challenge

The shopper sees a payment notification from an earlier purchase. Keep it separate from this unpaid basket.

Language-check answers

1. B - refund Correct. A refund returns money after payment; payment hasn't begun.
2. A - has not yet been taken Correct. Correcting the basket does not complete the still-unpaid transaction.

05 • Conversations

1. One mug entered twice - A cashier corrects the item count before payment. In this fictional shop, one mug costs eight dollars and no other charges apply.
2. A notification is not the register's final status - A cashier responds when a card-payment screen pauses.

3. A receipt choice before leaving - After a cash purchase, a cashier clarifies a shopper's preferred receipt format.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | The quantity was correct but the size was not

A shopper buys one medium shirt. The basket shows one large because a loose tag from another item was scanned. The selected medium is C218-M; the mistakenly scanned large tag is C218-L. The prices are equal, and payment has not started.

Role A: Cashier: correct the identified variation without claiming a price difference.

Role B: Shopper: need the receipt to identify the actual medium shirt.

Possible opening: The total is right, but the description says large.

Success checks

- Distinguish price accuracy from item accuracy.
- Confirm the medium item code.
- Check the corrected record before payment.

Add a complication: The shopper assumes equal prices mean the item record need not be corrected.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Discussing returns and exchanges at the counter

Explain the stated exchange conditions without promising an unavailable replacement.

CASE

In this fictional store, an unused shirt with tags and a receipt can be exchanged within thirty days. The shopper bought it ten days ago and wants a larger size. A receipt is present; larger-size stock remains unchecked. Explain eligibility and the stock uncertainty without stating universal return rights.

Teach this move

A qualifying return does not create stock. Check the purchase conditions and then the requested replacement separately.

Vocabulary to check: proof of purchase, exchange, refund, store credit.

Model response

Your receipt shows the shirt was bought ten days ago. Under this store's stated terms, the unused shirt with its tags qualifies for an exchange within thirty days. We still need to check whether the larger size is here. I'll check that before we agree on the replacement.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. Eligibility alone does not establish local stock.

Second-round challenge

The larger size is unavailable. Ask about other stated options rather than invent an exception.

Language-check answers

1. A - exchange Correct. An exchange replaces the purchased item with another.
2. D - value to spend at the store Correct. Store credit provides value usable at the store.

05 • Conversations

1. The receipt qualifies; the size still needs checking - A cashier handles a shirt exchange.

2. A gift without the original price receipt - A shopper asks what a gift receipt can support.
3. A request outside the stated window - A cashier responds to an exception request.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Different item, different price

An eligible exchange involves a \$20 shirt. The shopper selects a different \$26 style. The fictional store permits this exchange with a \$6 additional payment. Stock is confirmed.

Role A: Cashier: explain the six-dollar difference before proceeding.

Role B: Shopper: can pay six but initially expects an even exchange.

Possible opening: Isn't an exchange always the same price?

Success checks

- Identify both item prices.
- Explain the difference rather than invent an exchange fee.
- Get the shopper's agreement before proceeding.

Add a complication: The shopper asks whether the six dollars is a fee rather than a price difference.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Explaining local stock and collection status

Separate order acknowledgment from pickup readiness.

CASE

A shopper's message acknowledges order R61 but is not a collection notification. One item is still being located. The collection colleague will update the shopper at 3:00, even if unresolved. Do not promise readiness or substitute another variation.

Teach this move

Use the message's wording and current physical status. An update time is not automatically a collection time.

Vocabulary to check: sales floor, stockroom, reserved item, collection notification.

Model response

That message confirms receipt of order R61; it isn't a collection notification. One item is still being located, so I can't say the order is ready. The collection colleague will update you at three, including if the search is unresolved. We won't substitute a different variation without asking you.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The shopper receives the actual status instead of a broader implication.

Second-round challenge

The shopper asks whether choosing another color automatically makes the order ready. Keep substitution and readiness separate.

Language-check answers

1. D - update Correct. The colleague promised new information at three.
2. C - order acknowledgment Correct. The message confirms that the order was received.

05 · Conversations

1. Received does not mean ready - An associate checks a shopper's order message.
2. Stockroom search for an empty shelf - An associate helps a shopper whose item is not on display.
3. A reservation has an end time - An associate confirms a shopper's held item.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Two customers have the same surname

Two collection orders are labeled Chen. Their references are C41 and C47. The shopper presents C47; only C41 is on the front shelf, while C47 is being checked in back.

Role A: Associate: use the order reference rather than surname alone.

Role B: Shopper: need C47 and are willing to wait for its status.

Possible opening: That bag has my surname. Is it mine?

Success checks

- Confirm C47 as the required reference.
- Do not release C41 because of a matching surname.
- Give an accurate update on the search for C47.

Add a complication: The shopper says the bag's color looks familiar.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Managing queues and offering practical assistance

Offer a concrete access option without making assumptions about the shopper.

CASE

A shopper using a mobility aid says the current checkout is too narrow. An accessible checkout is open at lane four. Ask what help they prefer, explain the available route, and ask a colleague to preserve their place; do not touch their belongings or aid without permission.

Teach this move

Address the shopper directly and offer the available route. Ask before handling personal belongings or mobility equipment.

Vocabulary to check: queue, accessible checkout, assistance call, checkout lane.

Model response

Lane four has the wider checkout space and is open now. Would you prefer directions or someone to accompany you? I'll ask my colleague to keep your place while we move the transaction. Please tell me what assistance you want; I won't assume you need help with your belongings.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The question gives the shopper control over the help offered.

Second-round challenge

The next shopper questions why the transaction is moving. Explain briefly without disclosing personal details.

Language-check answers

1. C - checkout access Correct. The shopper needs space at the payment point.
2. B - how you would like me to help Correct. The indirect question uses subject-verb order and 'me' after 'like'.

05 • Conversations

1. A wider checkout without unwanted help - An associate responds to a shopper's access request.

2. A price query blocks the lane - A cashier explains a delay without disclosing another shopper's purchase.

3. An assistance call with a useful location - An associate requests help for a shopper on the sales floor.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | The shopper wants a seated pause

A shopper becomes tired in a long checkout queue and asks for a seat, without describing a medical emergency. A customer seat is available beside lane one; the cashier can call them at their turn.

Role A: Associate: offer the stated seat and preserve the shopper's place.

Role B: Shopper: want to keep your basket and hear when your turn arrives.

Possible opening: Could I sit down without losing my place?

Success checks

- Respond to the requested practical help.
- Keep the basket choice with the shopper.
- Confirm how the cashier will call the shopper.

Add a complication: A colleague starts asking personal health questions unrelated to arranging the seat.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Handing over a till and an unfinished query

Give amounts, open checks, and a named next owner.

CASE

At shift change, the expected drawer balance is \$180 and the recorded count is \$175. A second check has not occurred, and the cause is unknown. A price query for item P32 also remains open. The incoming supervisor accepts both checks; do not accuse anyone or describe a loss as proved.

Teach this move

A discrepancy is a mismatch, not an established cause. Distinguish a cash check from a separate customer's price query.

Vocabulary to check: till float, cash discrepancy, void, shift log.

Model response

The first count is one hundred seventy-five dollars against an expected one hundred eighty, a five-dollar difference. The second check and cause are still open. Item P32 also has an unresolved price query. Please confirm you'll take both follow-ups and keep the two issues separate in the shift log.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised report states the evidence without accusing anyone.

Second-round challenge

Someone blames the prior cashier before the check. Keep the report factual without suggesting an unrecorded cash adjustment.

Language-check answers

1. B - five-dollar Correct. The difference between the two figures is five dollars.
2. A - cancelled Correct. A void cancels a transaction or item entry.

05 • Conversations

1. A five-dollar difference needs checking - An outgoing cashier gives a shift-change report.
2. The starting float is not sales revenue - A new cashier asks about a shift report.

3. An unfinished call needs a named owner - A cashier passes a callback request to the next shift.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A till transfer and a missing acknowledgment

A cashier transferred a price-query record to the service desk but has no acknowledgment. The customer is waiting at lane two. The desk colleague can accept it now.

Role A: Outgoing cashier: confirm actual acceptance before leaving.

Role B: Service colleague: accept the query for item J18 and tell the customer where to wait.

Possible opening: I sent the query earlier; can you confirm you're handling it?

Success checks

- Distinguish sending from acceptance.
- Name J18 and the waiting location.
- Confirm who will give the next update.

Add a complication: The sender initially treats a sent message as a completed customer response.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and switches roles and repeats the exchange. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All shops, transactions, stock records, policies, and incidents are fictional English practice. This course covers frontline interactions, not retail strategy, merchandising management, financial advice, or universal consumer-law rules. Follow the employer's actual payment, privacy, safety, and returns procedures; refer exceptions and restricted decisions to the responsible staff.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

BLS Occupational Outlook Handbook: Retail Sales Workers

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/sales/retail-sales-workers.htm>

BLS Occupational Outlook Handbook: Cashiers

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/sales/cashiers.htm>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.